

90-Day English Mastery Roadmap

Vocabulary • Pronunciation • Impressive Accent

A step-by-step, week-by-week system built for speed and consistency

The promise (and the honest truth). In 90 days of focused daily practice you can make a dramatic improvement in **clarity, rhythm, confidence and word power**. A fully native-sounding accent takes longer for most adults, but a **clear, consistent, impressive accent** is absolutely achievable in this window. The goal is **intelligibility first, imitation second**.

The 4 principles that make this fast

- **Little and daily beats a lot and rarely.** 90 minutes every day (or 2 x 45) outperforms 10 hours on Sunday.
- **Ear before mouth.** You can't produce a sound you can't hear. Every drill starts with careful listening.
- **Record yourself, always.** Your phone is your best teacher. Compare against the model, fix one thing at a time.
- **Learn words in chunks, with sound.** Never store a word without its audio, its stress and a real phrase.

Roadmap at a glance

Phase	Weeks	Focus	Outcome
0. Setup	Days 1-2	Choose target accent, record baseline, install tools	Clear starting point and plan
1. Foundation	1-3	Individual sounds (vowels and consonants), sound map	Clean, accurate core sounds
2. Rhythm & Words	4-6	Word stress, sentence stress, connected speech, word families and collocations	Natural rhythm, smoother speech
3. Accent Shaping	7-9	Intonation, daily shadowing, phrasal verbs, idioms, academic vocabulary	Melody of the accent, expressive voice
4. Automation	10-12	Impromptu speaking, real conversations, presentations	Fluent, confident, automatic use

Before you begin: choose ONE target accent

Mixing accents slows progress. Pick **General American (GA)** or **British Received Pronunciation / Standard Southern British (RP)** and stay with it for all 90 days. GA has the most free learning material online; RP is excellent if you plan to study or work in the UK or Commonwealth. All examples in this guide work for both unless noted.

0 Phase 0: Setup and Baseline (Days 1-2)

- **Record your baseline.** Read a 1-minute passage aloud AND speak freely for 2 minutes on "Introduce yourself and your goals." Save both as *Day-1.mp3*. You will re-record on Days 30, 60 and 90 to see real progress.
- **Do a self-diagnosis.** Listen and note: which sounds are hard (th, v/w, r, short/long vowels)? Do you drop word endings? Is your speech flat (monotone) or too fast?
- **Install your toolkit** (all have free tiers): Anki (flashcards), a voice recorder, YouGlish, a dictionary with audio (Cambridge or Merriam-Webster), and one AI feedback app such as ELSA Speak or Speechling.
- **Create a folder system:** /Recordings, /Vocabulary, /Shadowing clips, /Mistake log. Keep it simple.
- **Book your practice slot.** Fix the same time daily. Habit beats motivation.

1 Your Daily 90-Minute Practice Template

Use this template every day. On light days, do a compressed 45-minute version (starred items only).

Time	Block	What to do
10 min	Warm-up *	Jaw, lips and tongue exercises; hum and read a short text aloud slowly and exaggerated. Try tongue twisters ("She sells sea shells...", "Red lorry, yellow lorry").
20 min	Sound of the day *	One target sound or pattern from the weekly plan: listen, mirror-watch your mouth, minimal-pair drills, then 5 sentences aloud, recorded.
20 min	Vocabulary *	Learn 8-10 new words in chunks (see Section 3), then 10 min of Anki spaced-repetition review.
25 min	Shadowing	One 30-60 second clip of your target accent, using the 5-step method (Section 2).
10 min	Free speaking *	Record 1-2 minutes on a topic of the day. Use at least 3 of today's new words.
5 min	Review and log	Play your recording. Write ONE thing to fix tomorrow in your mistake log.

2 The Accent Engine: 5-Step Shadowing Method

Shadowing (speaking along with a native speaker, slightly behind them) is the single fastest way to absorb rhythm, melody and connected speech. Use 30-60 second clips from a speaker you enjoy: TED Talks (with transcripts), BBC Learning English, podcast interviews, or Rachel's English videos for American.

Step	Action	Why it works
1	Listen to the clip 3 times while reading the transcript. Look up unknown words.	Builds understanding and awareness of the target sound.
2	Mark up the transcript: underline stressed words, slash (/) at pauses, arrows for rising or falling voice.	Makes the invisible rhythm visible.
3	Speak along with the audio, transcript in hand, at 0.85x speed if needed.	Trains timing and pace.
4	Shadow without transcript , 1-2 words behind the speaker. Repeat 5-8 times.	Forces your ear to lead your mouth.
5	Record and compare. Play the original, then your version. Note 2 differences. Repeat once more.	Self-correction is where the improvement happens.

3 Vocabulary Mastery System

Target: **8-10 new words per day, 6 days a week, one review day.** That is about **650-750 deeply learned words** in 90 days, far better than 2,000 words you forget. Quality and recall matter more than quantity.

The 6-step method for every new word

#	Step	Example (word: <i>meticulous</i>)
1	Hear it first. Listen to the dictionary audio 3 times; repeat aloud.	meh-TIK-yuh-luss. Stress on the 2nd syllable.
2	Note the stress and part of speech.	adjective; stress: me-TIC-u-lous
3	Learn it in a chunk (collocation) , not alone.	"meticulous attention to detail", "meticulous planning"
4	Write your own sentence about YOUR life.	"My manager is meticulous about deadlines."
5	Add to Anki with audio + a gap-fill sentence on the front, meaning + your sentence on the back.	Front: "She is _____ about her notes."
6	Use it aloud 3 times within 24 hours (recordings, conversations, voice notes).	Activation = long-term memory.

Spaced repetition schedule (Anki handles it automatically, or do it manually)

- Review after **1 day**, then **3 days**, **7 days**, **14 days**, **30 days**.
- Aim for **85%+ recall**. If lower, you are learning too many new words per day. Cut to 6-7.
- Once a week, do a **Review Day**: test yourself on all the week's words by speaking short sentences without notes.

Where to get the words (in priority order)

- **Oxford 3000 and 5000** (free lists on Oxford Learner's Dictionaries): the most useful high-frequency words by level.

- **Academic Word List (AWL):** 570 word families for professional and academic English.
- **What you actually read and hear.** Words from your shadowing clips, news (BBC, The Guardian) and podcasts stick best because they have context.
- **Your own field.** Add 3-5 profession-specific words per week (tech, medicine, finance, law, etc.).

4 Week-by-Week Plan

Each week has one **sound/pronunciation focus**, one **vocabulary theme**, and one **speaking task**. Symbols in slashes are IPA; respellings in quotes help if IPA is new to you.

Phase 1: Foundation (Weeks 1-3): Master the sounds

Wk	Pronunciation focus	Vocabulary theme	Speaking task / Milestone
1	IPA basics; short vs long vowels (ship/sheep, full/fool, live/leave); the schwa /ə/ (about, banana)	Daily-life essentials (Oxford 3000, A2-B1)	Read aloud 3 min daily. Milestone: can identify and say 10 vowel pairs.
2	Tricky consonants: TH (think/this), V vs W (vine/wine), R and L (right/light)	Work and study words	Describe your day in 2 min. Milestone: TH and V/W correct in slow speech.
3	Aspirated p/t/k (pin vs spin); final consonants (cold, asked); -s and -ed endings (worked /t/, played /d/, wanted /ɪd/)	People, emotions and relationships	Record and compare with Day 1. Checkpoint 1 (see Section 6).

Phase 2: Rhythm and Words (Weeks 4-6): Sound natural

Wk	Pronunciation focus	Vocabulary theme	Speaking task / Milestone
4	Word stress: rules and patterns; noun vs verb (REcord / reCORD); suffix stress (photoGRAPHy)	Word families: prefixes and suffixes	Say 20 multi-syllable words with correct stress, no notes.
5	Sentence stress and rhythm: stress content words; reduce function words (weak forms: "can" = /kən/, "to" = /tə/)	Collocations: make/do/take/have/get	Retell a news story in 90 seconds with clear rhythm.
6	Connected speech: linking, dropping sounds, flapping (water, better), "gonna/wanna" as recognition	Top 50 phrasal verbs	Shadow a fast-paced interview clip. Checkpoint 2 at Day 60 start.

Phase 3: Accent Shaping (Weeks 7-9): Add melody and personality

Wk	Pronunciation focus	Vocabulary theme	Speaking task / Milestone
7	Intonation: falling for statements, rising for yes/no questions, lists, and emotion and emphasis	Academic and professional words (AWL)	Record a 3-min talk with marked intonation.
8	Intensive shadowing: 2 clips daily; copy the speaker's melody, pauses and energy	Idioms and fixed expressions (30 most common)	Mimic one speaker for a full week.
9	Accent polish: voice quality, pace, pausing, chunking ideas; fix your personal top-3 problem sounds	Nuance words: formal vs informal, synonyms with different feelings	Record a 5-min presentation. Checkpoint 3 (Day 90 prep).

Phase 4: Automation (Weeks 10-12): Make it automatic

Wk	Focus	Vocabulary theme	Speaking task / Milestone
10	Impromptu speaking: pick a random topic, speak 3-5 min with no prep, using new words	Your profession / field-specific words	5 impromptu talks. Track number of fillers (um, uh).
11	Real conversations: language exchange partner, tutor, or study group; send daily voice notes	Gap-fill: review all Anki cards you keep missing	3 live conversations of 15+ minutes each.
12	Final assessment: re-record Day-1 passage and free talk; compare with all checkpoints	Full vocabulary review and test	Celebrate. Build your next-90-day plan .

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Sound Toolkit: Common Trouble Spots and How to Fix Them

Sound / Pattern	Common mistake	Fix	Practice pairs
TH /θ/ /ð/	Replaced by t / d / s / z	Tip of tongue lightly between teeth; blow air (think) or add voice (this)	think/sink, thank/tank, they/day
V vs W	Both sound the same	V: upper teeth touch lower lip. W: round lips, no teeth	vine/wine, vest/west, veal/wheel
Short vs long vowels	"ship" and "sheep" sound identical	Long vowels are tenser and longer; short ones are relaxed	ship/sheep, full/fool, pull/pool
/æ/ /e/ /ʌ/	bad, bed, bud merge	Drop the jaw wide for /æ/; mid for /e/; relaxed for /ʌ/	bad/bed/bud, cat/cut, man/men
R sound	Tapped or rolled r	Curl or bunch the tongue back without touching the roof; lips slightly rounded	right/light, road/load, red/led
Aspiration	p, t, k with no puff of air	Feel a burst of air on your palm for pin, tin, kin. None in spin, stin, skin	pin/spin, top/stop, key/ski
Word endings	Dropping final consonants (cold, asked, worked)	Say them lightly but clearly; link to the next word	cold water, asked him, worked hard
-s and -ed endings	Always /s/ and /ed/	-s: /s/ cats, /z/ dogs, /ɪz/ boxes. -ed: /t/ worked, /d/ played, /ɪd/ wanted	watches, laughed, needed
Schwa /ə/	Every vowel pronounced in full	Weaken unstressed syllables: about, banana, family ("fam-lee")	photograph vs photography
Stress and rhythm	Every syllable gets equal beat (syllable-timed)	English is stress-timed: stress content words, squeeze function words	"I WANT to GO to the STORE"

Mirror + record routine for any new sound (5 minutes)

- **Listen** to the sound 5 times in isolation, then in words (dictionary audio or YouGlish).
- **Watch your mouth** in a mirror. Compare with the tongue and lip position shown on Sounds of Speech (University of Iowa).
- **Say minimal pairs** slowly, then faster. Record and check whether the two words sound different.
- **Put the sound into 5 real sentences**, then into a 30-second speech. Record it.
- **Intelligibility test:** dictate a sentence to your phone's speech-to-text. If it types what you meant, your sound is clear.

6 Progress Tracking and Checkpoints

Checkpoint	When	What to do	Success looks like
Baseline	Day 1	Record 1-min reading + 2-min free talk	Saved as your reference
1	Day 21	Re-record both; compare with baseline; test 10 minimal pairs	Core sounds clearer; fewer endings dropped
2	Day 42-45	Record a 3-min retelling; check stress and linking	Speech sounds more rhythmic and connected
3	Day 60	Re-record baseline; ask a friend or tutor for blind feedback	Noticeably more natural melody
Final	Day 90	Re-record everything; take a 50-word vocabulary recall test	Clear, confident speech; 85%+ word recall

Weekly self-audit (10 minutes every Sunday)

- Did I practise at least 6 of 7 days? (Consistency target: 85%)
- Which ONE sound or habit improved most this week? Which one is still my weakest?
- How many new words did I actually *use* aloud, not just memorize?
- What is my single focus for next week?

7 Best Free and Low-Cost Resources

Purpose	Resources
Pronunciation reference	Cambridge Dictionary and Merriam-Webster (UK/US audio), Forvo (real speakers), YouGlish (words in real videos), Sounds of Speech (Univ. of Iowa, animated mouth positions)
Teachers and courses (video)	Rachel's English (American), BBC Learning English (British), English with Lucy, Pronunciation with Emma, Speak English with Vanessa
AI and speech feedback	ELSA Speak, Speechling (free human coach feedback), your phone's dictation (Google Recorder or similar)
Vocabulary tools	Anki, Oxford 3000/5000 lists, Academic Word List, Vocabulary.com, Merriam-Webster Word of the Day
Books	<i>English Pronunciation in Use</i> (Cambridge), <i>Ship or Sheep?</i> (Ann Baker), <i>American Accent Training</i> (Ann Cook), <i>English Vocabulary in Use</i> (Cambridge), <i>Word Power Made Easy</i> (Norman Lewis)
Shadowing and listening	TED Talks (interactive transcripts), BBC 6 Minute English, All Ears English, podcast interviews you genuinely enjoy
Conversation practice	italki or Preply tutors, HelloTalk and Tandem (language exchange), local English clubs or Toastmasters

Availability and features of apps change, so check the current free tier before you commit.

8 Mistakes That Slow You Down (Avoid These)

- **Switching accents or resources every week.** Pick one model and stay with it.
- **Only listening, never recording.** You cannot hear your own errors until you replay yourself.
- **Memorizing word lists without sound or context.** You will forget them and mispronounce them.
- **Trying to fix everything at once.** Work on one sound or habit per day. Depth beats breadth.

- **Speaking too fast.** Slow, clear and rhythmic sounds more impressive than fast and blurry.
- **Skipping the review day.** Retention is built during review, not first exposure.
- **Chasing a "perfect native" voice.** Aim to be clear, expressive and confident. That is what impresses listeners.

Your first 3 actions today (do them in the next hour)

- **Record your Day-1 baseline** (1-min reading + 2-min free talk).
- **Choose your target accent** (American or British) and pick one shadowing speaker.
- **Learn your first 8 words** using the 6-step method and start your Anki deck.

Consistency is the secret. Ninety focused days can change how you sound and how you are heard for the rest of your life.